Michael demonstrating his techniques on segmented woodturning

A self-taught woodturner

Before losing his sight, Michael worked at a hospital as a Cardiopulmonary Technician and did flat woodwork in his garage in his spare time. "I made furniture and grandfather clocks and lots of scrollsaw pieces. I had never seen a bowl turned on a lathe", he says. About 11 years ago he developed a rare disease called AZOOR. "At that time, there were only 500 documented cases and no one ever went blind. I was the first," he explained. "The disease process started with the flu and caused a type of autoimmune disease in which the antibodies that were developed to destroy the flu started to destroy the cones and rods of my eyes. It took a year to diagnose the rare disease and then a year of unsuccessful experimental treatments before I went completely blind. I have absolutely no vision at all. Totally dark."

In the meantime, as he did not expect to lose his sight, Michael started a small sawmill business with his brother-in-law and it was here that he had his first experience of turning a bowl. "A customer – now a good friend – placed into my hands a bowl that he had turned on a lathe. I knew nothing about turning on a lathe, I had never even seen one turned when I had sight. My friend said that I should try turning a bowl. I told him I did not know how and was it not dangerous? He told me that if I went really slowly and took my time I could make a bowl. My sons had a mini lathe that was in the corner of the garage that they made pens on a few times, so I decided to venture out into the garage for the first time in three or four years and give it a try. I took a faceplate and screwed it to a glued-up piece of wood and started chunking out a bowl. I went into the house and told my wife 'I'm a wood turner.'"

Michael admits that his first attempt was not entirely successful: "It looked awful, something like a dog dish! Thick and heavy and flat on the bottom." However, this did not put him off him and he was determined to learn more about woodturning.

After buying a lathe, he bought some tools and several videos about woodturning. "I would listen to the videos and then go into the garage and practise what I understood. My wife would come home from work and watch the video with me and take a large mixing bowl and wooden spoon and show me how she would see the turner's hands and the position of the tool with the mixing bowl and spoon. I would go into the garage the next day and try again. So I taught myself to turn."

Turning style

When he first started turning, Michael made utility-type bowls but he has now

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